Luke speaks.

Keynotes and conference workshops

From care leaver to care leader.

Seven keynotes with Luke Rodgers BEM, for everyone who works with children in care.



The CareLeaders TCL Luke Speaks is powered by The Care Leaders

Contents



03 Meet Luke

04 How every keynote works

05 Choose a talk

06 Living a Careless Life

08 Just Say Yes

10 The Power of the Profile

12 Tools for Schools

14 Lived Experience Leadership

16 From Care Leaver to Care Leader

18 Be the First Yes

20 It doesn't stop at a keynote

21 The workbook

22 The online course

23 The video

24 What people say

25 Book Luke for your event



Luke Rodgers BEM
Founder and CEO, The Care Leaders

Keynotes with Luke Rodgers BEM

Meet Luke

From care leaver to care leader.

"I went into care at 10. At 15 I was living in a B&B, and at 18 I was in a caravan. I gave my first keynote at 19, standing in front of a room of professionals and telling them what care had felt like from the inside. I've been doing it ever since, because it's still one of the fastest ways I know to change how people see children in care.

That's why I set up The Care Leaders: to go from care leaver to care leader, and to help others make the same move. Since then I've led the national engagement on England's new fostering standards, been a Knowledge Equity Fellow at Saïd Business School, Oxford, and been awarded the British Empire Medal."

British Empire Medal
Awarded in 2018.

Knowledge Equity Fellow
Saïd Business School, University of Oxford.

National leadership
Engagement lead on England's new fostering standards.

Spoken at
Community Care Live, the Local Government Association, NAVSH national conferences, and online to audiences in Australia.

45+
keynotes since the start of 2024

30 to 400
people in the room, from team away days to national conferences

4,000+
delegates expected since 2024, from organisers' booking numbers

400
people in the largest single room so far

How every keynote works

Three parts. Every talk.

Whichever talk you choose, it follows the same structure, so delegates get the story, the reason behind it and the tools to use it.

1 Story

Luke's story opens every talk.

Real moments from growing up in care: what helped, what hurt, and what the adults around him never saw. It's what makes the room listen.

2 Theory

The evidence underneath gives it rigour.

What the research says about the patterns in the story, so the learning rests on more than one person's experience.

3 Action

The room leaves with something to do.

Practical tools and one commitment each person can act on the next day, with questions to take back to their team.

45 to 90 minutes
Keynote or conference workshop

In person or live online
Any size, from a team day to 400 people

Shaped around your audience
On a 30-minute planning call

Time for questions
And the slides to share afterwards

Choose a talk

Seven talks, one spine.

Every talk follows the same spine: Luke's story, the theory behind it, and tools people can use straight away. 45 to 90 minutes, in person or online. Not sure which fits? Tell us about your audience and we'll recommend one.

For mixed audiences

Living a Careless Life

For foster carers

Just Say Yes

For social workers

The Power of the Profile

For schools and colleges

Tools for Schools

For senior leaders

Lived Experience Leadership

For care-experienced young people

From Care Leaver to Care Leader

For employers

Be the First Yes



Or one built for your audience.

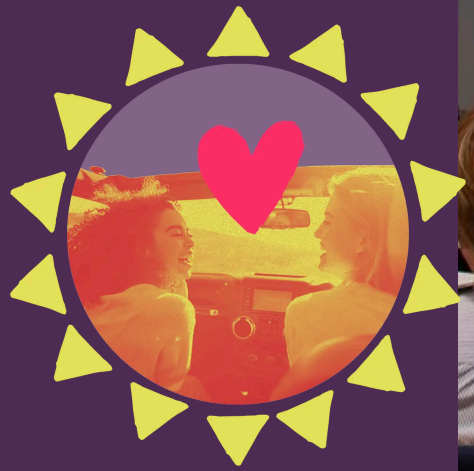
Tell us who's in the room and we'll shape a talk around them.

1 of 7 Flagship talk

For mixed audiences

Living a Careless Life

What it is really like to grow up in care.





The idea

What it is really like to grow up in care.

Staff and leaders make decisions about children in care every day without hearing what it is like from the inside. Language, processes and missed moments can make a child feel like a case, and nobody in the room notices. This is the talk that changes that.

1 Story

Growing up in care, from the inside

Where the system helped, and where it got in the way

The adults who made a difference, and what they actually did

2 Theory

What the research says about the patterns in the story

How meetings, moves and language make a child feel like a case

Why trust is built in small moments

3 Action

Four tools, including Just Say Yes and Spot, Soothe, Shift

Reflection questions to take back to the team

One thing each person will do differently on Monday

By the end, delegates will

- What children in care notice that adults miss
- The moments that build trust, and the ones that break it
- How systems and language can make children feel like a case
- What one adult can change

Who it's for
Whole services, conferences, schools and corporate parenting boards

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online

For foster carers

Just Say Yes

"What young people in care need most isn't perfection, it's people."





The idea

Inspiring foster carers to say yes.

Saying yes to a child often starts with a profile full of risks, behaviours and past moves, and rarely the full story. Then carers are asked to meet needs shaped by trauma and loss without training that explains why. That is not a failure of fostering. It is a gap in how we prepare carers, and this talk bridges it.

1 Story

What it felt like to be judged by a profile

Being misunderstood, and being believed in

The foster carer who made a life-changing difference

2 Theory

Attachment, and how early relationships shape behaviour

Trauma, the brain and emotional regulation

Behaviour as a survival strategy

3 Action

Reframing behaviour through a trauma-informed lens

Simple ways to build trust and calm conflict

A home that feels safe and predictable

By the end, delegates will

- Understand how profiles shape what carers expect
- Respond to hard moments with empathy, not fear
- Know the basics of trauma, attachment and behaviour as communication
- Leave with simple tools for daily care, and the confidence to say yes

Who it's for
Foster carers, kinship carers and the fostering teams who support them

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online

3 of 7

For social workers

The Power of the Profile

"Be the social worker who turns stories into stepping stones, not stumbling blocks."





The idea

One day, the child will read what you wrote.

The profile a social worker writes becomes a child's introduction to a school, a carer or a panel. It is often built from inherited case notes and incident logs, so the child is described by what went wrong. When the answer is no, it is the social worker who carries it. This talk is for the practitioner who knows the young person behind the paperwork.

1 Story

What it felt like to read his own file

Being introduced through incident logs

Being turned away because of paperwork that wasn't him

2 Theory

Trauma-informed storytelling

Identity, attachment and the psychology of language

Why some profiles raise fear and others build belief

3 Action

Writing profiles that are honest, balanced and hopeful

Reframing behaviour so it reduces fear

Sharing information in a way that helps others say yes

By the end, delegates will

- Write profiles that inspire belief, not fear
- Reframe behaviour through a trauma-informed lens
- Understand the emotional and ethical weight of telling a child's story
- Feel renewed confidence in advocating for a child

Who it's for
Social workers at every level, team managers, supervising social workers, IROs and students

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online

For schools and colleges

Tools for Schools

"Be the teacher who says yes."





The idea

Read the behaviour, then reach for the right tool.

For a child in care, school can become another place to feel misunderstood, especially when their past arrives as a behaviour record. Most teacher training doesn't cover trauma or children in care, yet schools are expected to be a critical support. This talk gives staff the understanding and the tools.

1 Story

His own school experience: labelled, excluded, then supported

The difference one teacher's belief can make

2 Theory

Attachment, trauma and development, made classroom-relevant

Language and stigma in school life

Where school and children's social care clash

3 Action

Three practical tools staff can use the next day

Responding to behaviour without escalating it

Building trust with children in care

By the end, delegates will

- Read behaviour as communication and respond in the moment
- Understand how language and stigma shape a child's school life
- Know what attachment and trauma look like in school
- Know where school and social care clash, and what to do about it

Who it's for
Headteachers, designated teachers, teachers and college staff

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online

5 of 7

For senior leaders

Lived Experience Leadership

"It's the way we think about our experiences that gives them meaning."





The impact of lived experience on service delivery and design.

We tend to see hard experiences as things that hold people back. This talk reframes them. A child who moves home is learning to adapt; a child who changes school is learning to read people and build relationships. Leaders who see lived experience this way work alongside people with it as leaders, not only for their story.

1 Story

Moves, school changes and new social workers, from the inside

How those experiences became skills

2 Theory

It is the meaning we give experiences that shapes them

Adaptability, communication, empathy and emotional intelligence

Lived experience as expertise

3 Action

Reflecting this mindset back to children and young people

Working alongside people with lived experience as leaders

Using lived experience in service design

By the end, delegates will

- See the skills that hard experiences can build
- Recognise lived experience as expertise, not only a story
- Reflect that back to the children and young people they work with
- Involve people with lived experience as leaders in their service

Who it's for
Senior leaders, leadership teams and anyone who works with children

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online

For care-experienced young people

From Care Leaver to Care Leader

"Your story isn't a limitation, it's a superpower."





The idea

Your story as a strength, not a setback.

Care-experienced young people are often described by other people's words: case notes, risk assessments and plans that follow them into school, housing and work. This talk helps them see that what they have lived through has built real skills, and that they can lead because of their experience, not in spite of it.

1 Story

Growing up in care and the challenges along the way

Becoming a national leader, speaker and founder

2 Theory

How the care system shapes identity

How adversity builds unexpected leadership skills

3 Action

Reframing experience as a strength

Building a future on confidence, purpose and self-belief

Leading change in their own lives and beyond

By the end, delegates will

- See their care experience as a strength, not a weakness
- Recognise the skills they already have
- Feel more confident about their future
- See themselves as people who can lead change

Who it's for
Care-experienced young people aged 14 and over, children in care councils and care leaver groups

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online

For employers

Be the First Yes

"Care leavers aren't asking for special treatment. They're asking for a chance."





The idea

Opening doors for care leavers in the workplace.

Care leavers often start working life without the family networks, references and safety nets most people take for granted. Employers want to do the right thing but worry about getting it wrong. Care leavers aren't asking for special treatment. They are asking for a chance, and this talk shows how to give one.

1 Story

His journey from care to employment

How one opportunity changed his future

2 Theory

The barriers care leavers face in work

The behavioural science behind opportunity, stigma and belonging

3 Action

Care-aware recruitment and induction

Mentoring, onboarding and support that work

Inclusive teams where care-experienced people can grow

By the end, delegates will

- Understand who care leavers are and what support really looks like
- Plan mentoring and onboarding that helps people stay
- Know how to make recruitment and induction care-aware
- Feel confident, not cautious, about being the first yes

Who it's for
Employers, HR and early careers teams, hiring managers and social value leads

Length
45 to 90 minutes

Format
Keynote or conference workshop, in person or live online

It doesn't stop at a keynote.

You also get:



1 The workbook

For every delegate, printed or digital, built around the talk.



2 The online course

Keep learning on The Care Leaders Online, at your own pace.



3 The video

The full keynote, recorded, for 12 months.

A workbook for every delegate.

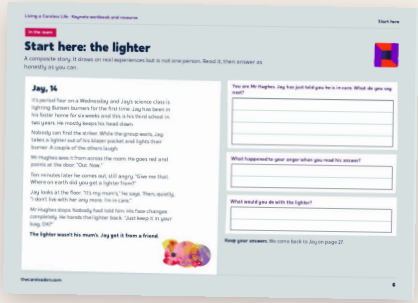
Built around the talk and laid out the same way: the story, the theory behind it, then the tools. Delegates keep one child or young person in mind as they go, so the learning lands on someone they know.

- Printed or digital, one for every delegate
- Activities for individuals and teams
- Quick reference cards for the tools
- Your logo on the cover on request

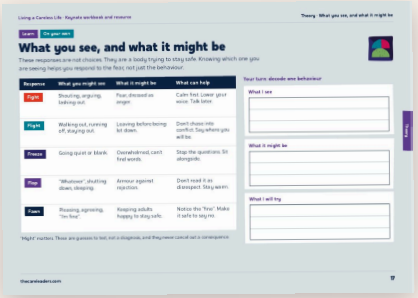
Shown: pages from the Living a Careless Life workbook, 38 pages.



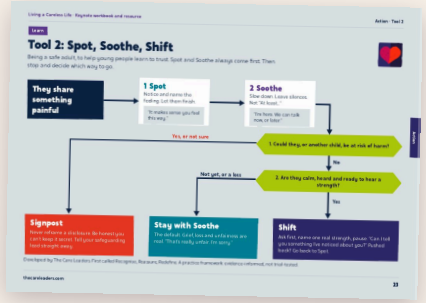
The cover



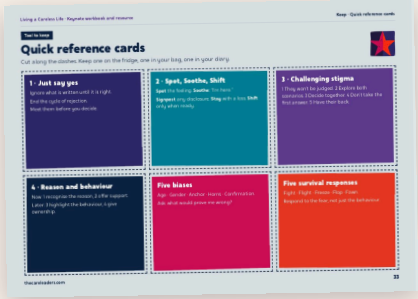
Story: start here



Theory, made practical



Action: a tool to use



Quick reference cards



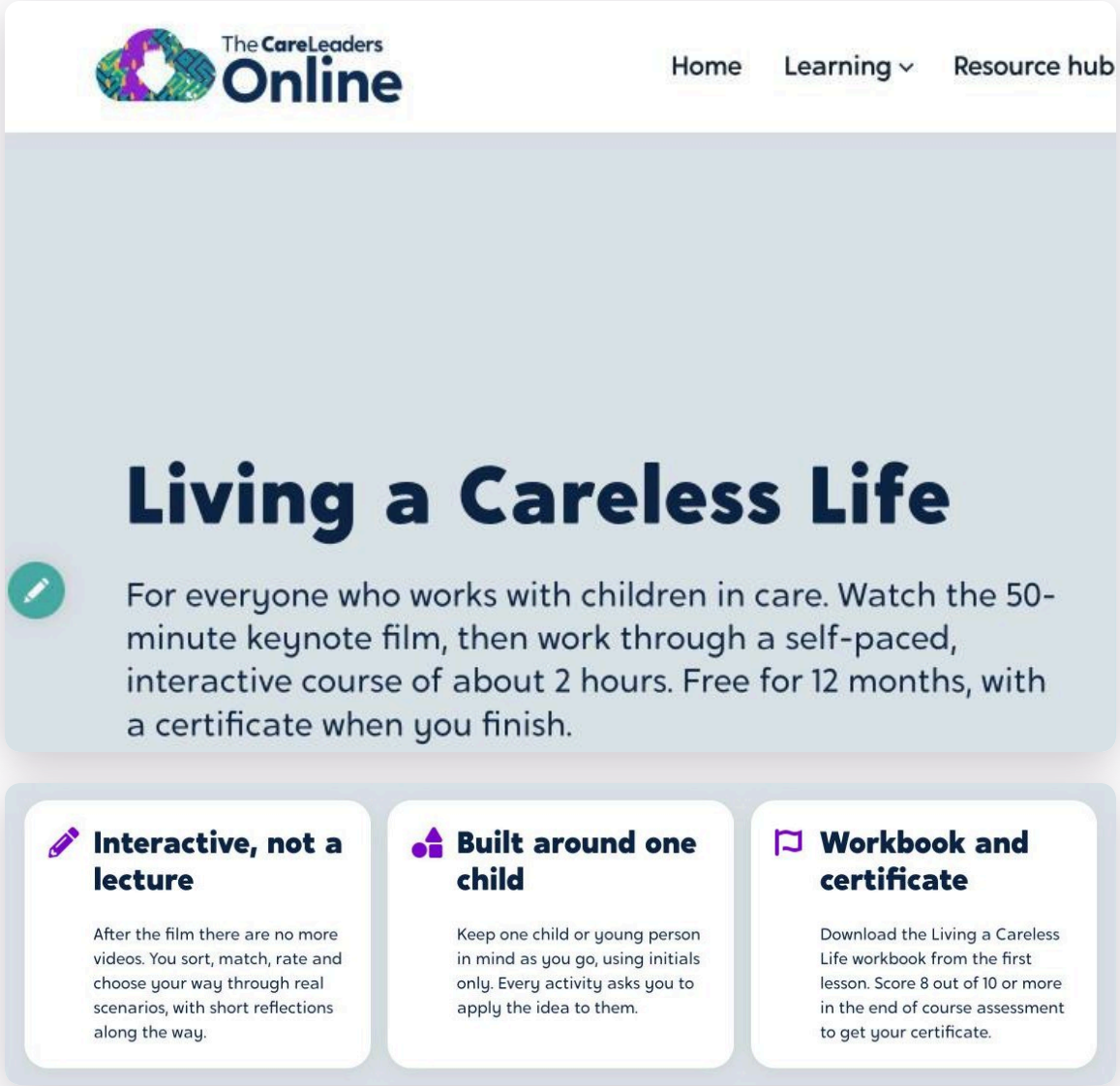
Where to go next

Keep learning on The Care Leaders Online.

At Living a Careless Life, delegates scan a QR code on the last slide and get the workbook straight away, then an email with free access to the online course for 12 months.

- Opens with the full 50-minute keynote film
- A self-paced course of about two hours
- Interactive, built around one child
- A certificate when you finish

For the other talks: ask us about online learning for your audience.





3 · The video

The full keynote, for 12 months.

Every delegate can watch the keynote again on The Care Leaders Online for 12 months after your event, and share it with colleagues who couldn't be there.

- The full keynote, filmed
- 12 months' access for every delegate
- A link you can put in your follow-up email
- The slides, so you can share them too



What people say

In their words.

Nothing was as transformative as hearing Luke speak about his life.

Dr Janet Rose, Principal, Norland College

I have seen them in action at many conferences and have heard professionals report changes in their own behaviour.

Professor Judy Sebba, Rees Centre, University of Oxford

You demand bravery and humanity in equal measure.

Maggie Atkinson, Former Children's Commissioner for England

Who we work with

Durham County Council

Kent County Council

Kirklees Council

Suffolk County Council

Buckinghamshire Council

NAVSH National Association of Virtual School Heads

NSPCC

The Fostering Network

National Fostering Group

pwc

Luke speaks.

Book Luke for your event.

1 **Tell us about your event**
The date, your audience and whether you're after a keynote, a workshop or both.

2 **Get availability and a fee**
Luke's availability, the fee and the talk we'd recommend. If Luke is free, we hold the date for 14 days.

3 **Confirm by email**
Reply to confirm and send a purchase order if you use them. Our booking terms come with the email.

4 **Before the day**
A 30-minute call to shape the talk around your audience, and a checklist of what Luke needs.

5 **After the day**
A follow-up call if you want one, with delegate feedback where we gathered it.

hello@thecareleaders.com · 0800 233 5597
Scan to tell us about your event. We reply within 3 working days.

iese Awards GOLD Winner 2026 The Public Sector Transformation Awards

Children & Young People Now Awards 2023 Winner

Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award, iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026.
Children & Young People Now Workforce Development Award 2023.

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